SCIENCE OF READING REVIEW:
UNIVERSITY OF CENTRAL ARKANSAS
TRADITIONAL AND ALTERNATIVE

On-Site Review: Date not reported

WHAT'S IN THIS REPORT?

This report uses evidence from an on-site review to examine how an educator preparation program prepares candidates to teach reading using scientific reading instruction, as Arkansas requires of every approved program. It is meant to inform a continuous improvement process that takes educator preparation programs closer to the goals needed to serve Arkansas's students.

The on-site reviews are carried out by Teacher Prep Inspection-US (TPI-US), an external review organization. TPI-US teams inspect coursework and course materials, observe instruction and clinical practice, review program data, and hold focus groups with candidates, faculty, mentor teachers, and school partners. Division of Elementary and Secondary Education staff participate in the review.

TPI-US rates the program in the three review areas of the Arkansas Literacy Review Framework:

- Review Area 1, "Quality of Literacy Coursework," is rated from course materials, syllabi, assignments, and observations of instruction.
- Review Area 2, "Quality of Field-Based Experiences," is rated from placement records, observation and feedback evidence, and focus groups with candidates, mentor teachers, faculty, and school partners.
- Review Area 3, "Quality of Performance Management and Continuous Improvement," is rated from program data systems, quality-control checkpoints, monitoring practice, and partnership evidence.

Every review area receives a rating. Depending on the framework version, the report may also rate each criterion; some earlier reports discuss every criterion without stating a separate rating for it. Performance Levels are defined as follows, in language drawn from the Arkansas Literacy Review Framework:

PERFORMANCE LEVEL	WHAT THE RATING MEANS
4 — EXCEEDS	Coursework and training CONSISTENTLY address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.
3 — MEETS	Coursework and training USUALLY address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.
2 — APPROACHING	Coursework and training INCONSISTENTLY address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.
1 — BELOW	Coursework and training RARELY OR DO NOT address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.

UNIVERSITY OF CENTRAL ARKANSAS

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REVIEW AREA PERFORMANCE LEVELS		
REVIEW AREA 1 LITERACY COURSEWORK	REVIEW AREA 2 FIELD-BASED EXPERIENCES	REVIEW AREA 3 PERFORMANCE MANAGEMENT
MEETS	**MEETS**	**MEETS**
CRITERIA REVIEWED		
9	11	7

PROGRAM INFORMATION

INSTITUTION NAME	University of Central Arkansas
LOCATION	Conway, Arkansas
PROGRAM REVIEWED	Undergraduate special education and K-6, MAT elementary and MAT special education pathways, literacy
PATHWAY	Traditional and Alternative
REVIEW FRAMEWORK	TPI-US Arkansas SOR Review Framework (2024)
REVIEWING BODY	Teacher Prep Inspection-US (TPI-US)
SITE VISIT DATES	Not reported

Note: Due to inclement weather, the scheduled in-person onsite visit was conducted virtually.

REVIEW AREA 1: QUALITY OF LITERACY COURSEWORK

REVIEW AREA 1 PERFORMANCE LEVEL

MEETS | 9 CRITERIA REVIEWED

CRITERION PERFORMANCE LEVELS (SPED K-6; MAT ELEM; MAT SPED)

Overview of the science of reading	**SPED K-6 Meets | MAT ELEM Meets | MAT SPED Meets**
Concepts of print instruction	**SPED K-6 Meets | MAT ELEM Meets | MAT SPED Meets**
Collaborative communication, oral language instruction	**SPED K-6 Exceeds | MAT ELEM Exceeds | MAT SPED Meets**
Phonological and phonemic awareness instruction	**SPED K-6 Meets | MAT ELEM Exceeds | MAT SPED Exceeds**
Phonics, orthography, automatic word recognition instruction	**SPED K-6 Meets | MAT ELEM Exceeds | MAT SPED Meets**
Fluency instruction	**SPED K-6 Meets | MAT ELEM Exceeds | MAT SPED Approaching**
Vocabulary instruction	**SPED K-6 Approaching | MAT ELEM Below | MAT SPED Exceeds**
Text comprehension instruction	**SPED K-6 Below | MAT ELEM Below | MAT SPED Meets**
Writing instruction	**SPED K-6 Approaching | MAT ELEM Below | MAT SPED Approaching**

WHAT THE REVIEWERS FOUND

Reviewers rated each Review Area 1 criterion separately for the undergraduate special education and K-6, MAT elementary and MAT special education pathways, and rated the review area itself as Meets for each of the three. All three pathways met expectations on the overview of the science of reading and on concepts of print. Strengths then diverged. The undergraduate special education and K-6 and MAT elementary pathways exceeded expectations in oral language instruction, and MAT elementary also exceeded expectations in phonological awareness, phonics and fluency. MAT special education exceeded expectations in phonological awareness and vocabulary. Weaknesses diverged as well. Reviewers rated text comprehension below expectations in the undergraduate special education and K-6 and MAT elementary pathways, and rated MAT elementary vocabulary and writing below expectations. Across all three pathways, reviewers found coursework grounded in theoretical models but short on structured application, peer modeling, field-based practice and HQIM evaluation.

REVIEW RECOMMENDATIONS

- Align and spiral literacy coursework across the undergraduate and MAT pathways, with explicit instruction, modeling and structured practice through peer teaching, scenario-based learning and fieldwork
- Strengthen vocabulary and comprehension instruction, including tiered vocabulary, morphology, and the reader, text and context factors that affect understanding
- Enhance writing instruction across the curriculum, with modeling, application of evidence-based writing strategies, English learner supports and training in valid writing assessment

REVIEW AREA 2: QUALITY OF FIELD-BASED EXPERIENCES

REVIEW AREA 2 PERFORMANCE LEVEL	
MEETS | 11 CRITERIA REVIEWED	
CRITERION PERFORMANCE LEVELS	
Selection of clinical placement schools	**Meets**
Selection of cooperating teachers (mentor teachers)	**Meets**
Opportunities to observe models of effective early literacy practice	**Meets**
Field-based placements provide opportunities to use HQIM	**Meets**
Responsibilities build to candidate readiness for full responsibility	**Meets**
Opportunities to apply learning about multilingual children	**Below**
Opportunities to apply learning about students who experience difficulty reading	**Meets**
Mentor teachers are skillful and can coach candidates	**Meets**
Faculty and supervisors guide and evaluate candidates through training	**Approaching**
Quality of written and oral feedback	**Approaching**
Student engagement and candidate impact on student learning	**Meets**

WHAT THE REVIEWERS FOUND

Reviewers found that field-based experiences met expectations overall. Placements matched candidates' licensure needs and prioritized schools using curricular materials aligned to structured literacy, and mentor teachers were selected against defined criteria including a valid license, three years of experience, and structured literacy and HQIM training. Candidates observed modeled instruction through video demonstrations and early field experiences, and used HQIM such as UFLI, LIPS and CORE Phonics assessments. Reviewers rated opportunities to apply learning about multilingual children below expectations, finding limited structured field experience with multilingual students. They rated faculty and supervisor guidance and the quality of written and oral feedback approaching expectations, because mentors were not routinely trained in observation and feedback protocols and oral and written feedback varied in alignment.

REVIEW RECOMMENDATIONS

- Expand university supervisor and mentor training to cover HQIM, RISE and science of reading practices, and establish protocols for clear, timely feedback tied to evidence of student learning

REVIEW AREA 3: QUALITY OF PERFORMANCE MANAGEMENT AND CONTINUOUS IMPROVEMENT

REVIEW AREA 3 PERFORMANCE LEVEL	
MEETS | 7 CRITERIA REVIEWED	
CRITERION PERFORMANCE LEVELS	
Quality of data the program collects and uses	**Meets**
Internal quality control gates (or checkpoints) and intervention plans	**Meets**
Quality of monitoring	**Meets**
Monitoring coursework quality, teaching quality, and clinical connections	**Meets**
Quality improvement planning	**Meets**
Partnerships improve candidate experiences with HQIM	**Meets**
Evaluation of partnerships for readiness to teach early literacy	**Meets**

WHAT THE REVIEWERS FOUND

Reviewers found that performance management and continuous improvement met expectations on all seven criteria. The program collected data through Chalk and Wire key assessments, Qualtrics surveys, AirTable placement tracking, problem of practice observation rubrics, licensure exam results, and graduate and employer surveys, and reviewed it at Data Day events and through the CAEP Standard 4 committee. A gate system at admission, at Internship I and II approval and at program exit governed candidate progression, with professional improvement plans for candidates who did not meet expectations. Quality improvement planning included timelines, responsible parties and success metrics. Reviewers found that mentor teacher feedback was captured mainly at midpoint and final evaluations, limiting real-time insight, and that partner schools engaged with HQIM implementation at different stages.

REVIEW RECOMMENDATIONS

- Strengthen clinical experience through continuous improvement, revising partnership agreements to align with literacy initiatives and HQIM access and defining clear metrics for evaluating partnership quality

Sources: TPI-US Written Report & Recommendations, University of Central Arkansas, revised report, conducted under the TPI-US Arkansas SOR Review Framework (2024). Rating scale language quoted from the Arkansas Literacy Review Framework.